

I feel no greater hesitance than when answering the dreaded what's-your-major question. Upon learning I voluntarily spend thousands of dollars to study history, the usual response is feigned interest or anecdotal complaints of the boring, unvaried, and overall useless timesink that history class was. So why, being such an enormous *waste of time*, is history studied in the first place? Why do the happenings of the past need to find their time in our present?

In a less practical sense, history is art in itself and the study of it is a means of enjoyment. There is inspiration taken from the people of the past that serves as our entertainment in the present. The skillful retelling of history's greatest moments inspires new stories and sparks wonder of the people who came before us. Peter Stearns says "history well told is beautiful", but history well preserved is just as great of a sight. People are often fascinated by reenactments and historical areas such as Colonial Williamsburg or Greenville Village, serving almost as a way to almost walk back in time. In this same way, history is often morphed to serve as an instrument of power instead of a tool of knowledge. The same amusing reenactments may fail to provide us with the whole story, presenting instead what Mike Wallace calls a "Mickey Mouse history" and what Mcneil calls "mythistory". Studying the pure happenings of history is often hindered by the inclusion of politics in the picture, turning history from art into campaigns. It is the study of not just history, but how it itself has been contorted that will allow us to form an understanding of the world.

History, in a more practical sense, provides an identity. On a smaller scale our identity can come from a family tree, on a much larger scale, a collective identity can be used to define "us", whether that be an ethnic group or a nation. William McNeil reasons that in the same way our individual memory shapes how we act with others, our collective memory guides us in how we should encounter others. When individuals or institutions experience time together, they

grow more cohesive through a bonded past. Many African-Americans, for example, identify with each other due to their ancestors shared experiences of slavery, Jim Crow, and the Civil Rights movement. The study of this history allows those who identify with it to often participate in community and public policy in similar ways, aided by the facts of the past. In turn, this knowledge of the collective's history brings those a part of it today closer. strengthened by a group history that forms the basis of all present relationships.

Perhaps the most critical reason to study history is to learn how things once were in the past to foster a better understanding of our present. While we worry about tomorrow, we often forget yesterday. It is for this reason McNeil reminds people "the way things are descends from the way they were yesterday". History is constantly being made as the fleeting present becomes the past meaning that change is happening constantly. It teaches us how our society came to be, the rise and fall of nations, how affairs between peoples were handled, the birth of conflicts that inflict us in the present, and, most importantly, the mistakes of the past. Alongside McNeil, John Gaddis reasons that we will learn from our past experiences whether we try to or not, but studying history is the best method to distinguish which experiences serve us best in the present and in "managing the future". This is done by giving people the background needed to make decisions regarding politics and public welfare. It is hard to support a constitutional amendment without knowing the constitution, just as it is hard for a general to repeat the same mistakes of previous wars given that knowledge. Lessons of humanity, the learning of peoples, places, and times apart from our own, also provides a greater scope of experiences to help us comprehend our own personal sphere. We analyze moral decisions and the consequences to determine what decisions we should make. We learn how encounters with other groups have happened to figure

out how we act now. By using history as “our laboratory”, using the experiences and events of the past as experiments, we can learn how society and humanity functions.

Gaddis’ distinction of “managing” the future versus “predicting” it serves as a clear caution for studying history: That despite the knowledge it provides, it is not a magic eight ball. Contrary to Fukuyama or Marx, history can not give us an exact forecast of the future, nor come to an end all together. Similar to these figures, others have tried to teach history in a way that best serves their own interests, whether it through a distorted identity or selective retelling of the past. To study history is to make interpretations and assess evidence in ways that assist our understanding of before without bias or political motivation, skills that prove necessary all throughout life. Although the retelling of history can be problematic in itself, time and time again we are enthused by standing where history took place. When done right, we can utilize the lessons learned by those before us to further progress not only society, but ourselves, and, through the continued collection of knowledge of the past, learn the people who shaped our present are not so unconnected after all.